



STUDY GUIDE • IEUMUN 2026

NATO

North Atlantic Treaty Organization

Undersea Infrastructure Security in the Baltic Sea

CHAIRS

Lucía Sobrado Louzao, Caspar Nitschke & Marie Matouchová

Contents

01	List of Abbreviations	3
02	Letter from Chairs	4
03	About the Committee	6
	Purpose	6
	Mandate and Treaty	7
	Partners and non-member states	8
04	About the Topic	10
	Geography and natural resources	12
	Vulnerability and danger	13
05	Past Actions and Current Situation	14
	NATO's response: Baltic Sentry	15
	Legal challenges	16
06	Bloc Positions and Key Stakeholders	18
	Baltic States	18
	Finland and Sweden	19
	Larger Western Members	19
	Russia	20
	China	21
07	QARMAs	22
	Bibliography	23
	Further Reading	26

01

List of Abbreviations

AI	Artificial Intelligence
BCS	Baltic Cable System – East-West Interlink cable between Lithuania and Sweden
DISEC	Disarmament and International Security Committee
EU	European Union
HDVC	High-Voltage Direct Current
NATO	North Atlantic Treaty Organization
PFP	Partnership for Peace
UNCLOS	United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea

02

Letter from Chairs

A LETTER FROM

Lucía Sobrado Louzao, Caspar Nitschke, Marie Matouchová

We welcome you to IEUMUN 2026 and, in particular, to the North Atlantic Treaty Organization, a forum and space in which dialogue, commitment, and cooperation become the keys to addressing challenges of our time, where the main topic that is going to be discussed is “Undersea Infrastructure Security in the Baltic Sea”. Next, the committee’s chair team will present themselves to the committee. This team is formed by Lucía Sobrado Louzao, Caspar Maurice Nitschke and Marie Matouchová.

Lucía is a second-year student at IE University in Law and International Relations, as well as an IB graduate from United World College Red Cross Nordic in Norway. She was a chair for IEUMUN 2025 in DISEC, and she has been a delegate in more than 20 MUNs, including Harvard National Model UN and London Model UN, both as a double delegation. Lucía is extremely excited to chair this committee and learn from all of you! If you want to contact her, write an email to lsobrado.ieu2024@student.ie.edu

Caspar is a business student at Hult International Business School in London. He came into IEUMUN last year as a delegate, which is part of why he is back, this time on the other side of the dais. He has also represented Harvard WorldMUN, and at the London International Model UN. Away from committee, Caspar spends most of his time on the entrepreneurial side of things, working in marketing and building projects of his own while studying in London, which is where he first got hooked on the blend of fast thinking, persuasion, and negotiation that MUN runs on. He is

looking forward to seeing what this committee makes of the topic. If you want to reach him, write to: caspar.nitschke@icloud.com

Marie is a second-year bachelor's student at Copenhagen Business School, studying Business Administration and Digital Management. In fact, her first university-level MUN has been IEUMUN. Since then, she has gained more experience not only as a chair but also as an Academic Director at CBSMUN 2026. Marie is very much looking forward to seeing you in beautiful Madrid.

To help you prepare for the conference, we have drafted a study guide that we encourage you to review. Additionally, please consider the guiding questions for your position papers, and feel free to also consult the additional reading sources we provide. Should any questions arise, please do not hesitate to reach out to us

Lucía Sobrado Louzao, Caspar Nitschke, Marie Matouchová

03

About the Committee

Purpose

The North Atlantic Organization Treaty was founded in 1949 with three main purposes:

- 1 Deterring Soviet expansionism
- 2 Forbidding the revival of nationalist militarism in Europe through a strong North American presence on the continent
- 3 Encouraging European political integration.

The aftermath of World War II saw much of Europe devastated in a way that is now difficult to envision. Approximately 36.5 million Europeans had died in the conflict, 19 million of them civilians. Shortly after the conflict, Communists, aided by the Soviet Union, were threatening elected governments across Europe as happened in Czechoslovakia in 1948¹.

The establishment of the Marshall plan, funded by the United States, gave a solid economic base to Western European democracies to come together to implement projects that promoted military cooperation and collective defence. After multiple negotiations, in April, 1949, the treaty was signed, being Article 5 one of the most important ones. The latter establishes that *an armed attack against one or more of them... shall be considered an attack against them all* and that following such an attack, each Ally would take *such action as it deems necessary, including the use of armed force* in response. The only time this Article was invoked was as a response to the 9/11 terrorist attacks in the United States in 2001.²

1 North Atlantic Treaty Organization. (n.d.). A short history of NATO. NATO. <https://www.nato.int/en/about-us/nato-history/a-short-history-of-nato>

2 North Atlantic Treaty Organization. (n.d.). A short history of NATO. NATO. <https://www.nato.int/en/about-us/nato-history/a-short-history-of-nato>

Mandate and Treaty

The purpose of NATO is therefore the one to guarantee the freedom and security of its member states through political and military means.

On one hand, political means refers to the promotion of democratic values and the provision of a structure to consult and cooperate on defence and security. On the other hand, military means refer to the last resort available if diplomatic means fail. This is inherent to NATO'S defensive alliance, since its main purpose is to keep its members safe and secure by maintaining a credible deterrence and defence posture.³

It is very important to highlight that **all decisions at NATO are taken by consensus. This means that in order to pass a resolution, all 32 member states must agree. Delegates must take this into account when negotiating and cooperating among different blocs.**

The most relevant articles of the treaty are summarised below. However, we encourage you to read the full treaty to acquire a deeper understanding of NATO's capabilities and obligations.

ARTICLE 1	<i>Settle any international dispute in which they may be involved by peaceful means in such a manner that international peace and security and justice are not endangered, and to refrain in their international relations from the threat or use of force in any manner inconsistent with the purposes of the United Nations.</i>
ARTICLE 2	<i>Contribute toward the further development of peaceful and friendly international relations. Seek to eliminate conflict in their international economic policies and will encourage economic collaboration between any or all of them.</i>
ARTICLE 3	<i>Parties, separately and jointly will maintain and develop their individual and collective capacity to resist armed attack</i>
ARTICLE 4	<i>Consult the territorial integrity, political independence or security of any of the Parties is threatened.</i>

³ North Atlantic Treaty Organization. (n.d.). What is NATO? NATO. <https://www.nato.int/en/what-is-nato>

ARTICLE 5	<i>The Parties agree that an armed attack against one or more of them in Europe or North America shall be considered an attack against them all. If such an armed attack occurs, each of them, in exercise of the right of individual or collective self-defence recognised by Article 51 of the Charter of the United Nations, will assist the Party or Parties so attacked by taking forthwith, individually and in concert with the other Parties, including the use of armed force, to restore and maintain the security of the North Atlantic area.</i>
ARTICLE 6	<i>For the purpose of Article 5, an armed attack on one or more of the Parties is deemed to include an armed attack: On the territory of any of the Parties in Europe or North America, on the Algerian Departments of France, on the territory of Turkey or on the Islands under the jurisdiction of any of the Parties in the North Atlantic area north of the Tropic of Cancer; On the forces, vessels, or aircraft of any of the Parties, when in or over these territories or any other area in Europe in which occupation forces of any of the Parties were stationed on the date when the Treaty entered into force or the Mediterranean Sea or the North Atlantic area north of the Tropic of Cancer.</i>
ARTICLE 8	<i>Each Party declares that none of the international engagements now in force between it and any other of the Parties or any third State is in conflict with the provisions of this Treaty, and undertakes not to enter into any international engagement in conflict with this Treaty.</i>
ARTICLE 10	<i>The Parties may, by unanimous agreement, invite any other European State to contribute to the security of the North Atlantic area to accede to this Treaty.</i>
ARTICLE 12	<i>After the Treaty has been in force for ten years, or at any time thereafter, the Parties shall, if any of them so requests, consult together for the purpose of reviewing the Treaty.</i>

Partners and non-member states

Even though the NATO Alliance only applies to the member states, NATO cooperates with multiple partners, primarily based on their geographic region. They contribute to many of NATO's core activities, from shaping policy to building defence capacity, developing interoperability and managing crises.

Partnership for Peace (PfP): bilateral cooperation between NATO and individual partner countries in the Euro-Atlantic area.

The PfP was established in 1994 to enable participants to develop an individual relationship with NATO, choosing their own priorities for cooperation, and the level and pace of progress. The countries involved are: Armenia, Azerbaijan, Georgia, Kazakhstan, Malta, Serbia, Tajikistan, Ukraine, Bosnia and Herzegovina, Ireland, Kyrgyzstan, Republic of Moldova, Switzerland, Turkmenistan, Uzbekistan.

Mediterranean Dialogue: aims to contribute to security and stability in the wider Mediterranean region.

The MD's core principles are: non-discrimination, self-differentiation, two-way engagement, non-imposition, diversity, and complementarity to other international initiatives in the region. The countries involved are: Algeria, Israel, Mauritania, Tunisia, Egypt, Jordan, Morocco.⁴

Istanbul Cooperation Initiative: offers non-NATO countries in the Middle East region the opportunity to cooperate with NATO.

The countries that belong to this alliance are: Bahrain, Qatar, Kuwait, United Arab Emirates.

Partners across the global: partnerships outside the formal structures, on an individual basis. Those countries include: Australia, Iraq, Mongolia, Pakistan, Colombia, Japan, New Zealand, Republic of Korea.

International organizations: European Union, United Nations, Organization for Security and Cooperation in Europe.

⁴ North Atlantic Treaty Organization. (n.d.). Mediterranean Dialogue. NATO. <https://www.nato.int/en/what-we-do/partnerships-and-cooperation/mediterranean-dialogue>

04

About the Topic

The Baltic Sea has become an environment dedicated to a web of subsea cables (Figure 1), carrying vital telecommunications traffic between EU and NATO states. It also serves as a maritime link between Russia and Kaliningrad.⁵

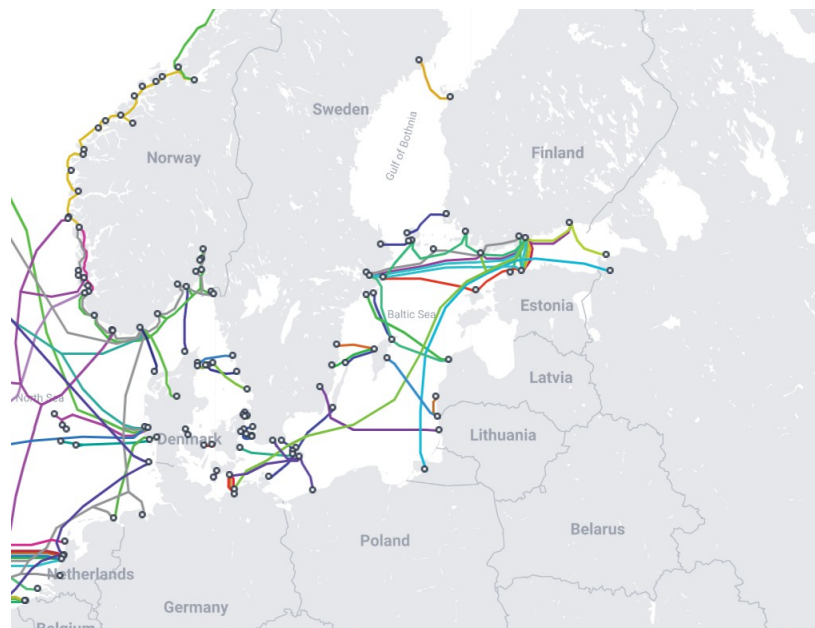


Figure 1. Submarine Cable Map ⁶

These subsea cables, described as small and fiber-optic, span over 1,448,409.6 km of the seafloor from the Atlantic to the Pacific. They carry 99% of the global internet data traffic,

⁵ O’Riordan, K. (2025, April 11). Geopolitics of Baltic subsea infrastructure. Brussels Institute for Geopolitics. <https://big-europe.eu/publications/2025-04-11-geopolitics-of-baltic-subsea-infrastructure>

⁶ Kivleniece, M. (2025). SEDE I: Cutting the cord—Undersea infrastructure security in the Baltic Sea. European Youth Parliament, The Hague 2025. <https://thehague2025.eyp.nl/to/sede-i/>

facilitating connection and communication across the globe. Despite their importance, these cables are fragile and highly prone to damage.⁷

“The Baltic has become the decisive sea for NATO.” This was said by Commander

T. Gerhard Bidlingmaier, Federal German Navy, in September 1958. He also outlined that the region held great strategic importance back then for NATO’s northern and eastern flank. From this historical source, it is also obvious that the region has always been one of the checkpoints of tensions between NATO and the USSR/Russia. Throughout the Cold War, NATO has viewed control of the Baltic as important for limiting Russian/Soviet naval freedom of movement while keeping Allied access open.⁸

In recent years, the world has been shaken by the growing number of incidents. Between November 2024 and January 2025 alone, seven cuts of the subsea cables have been registered. Suspicions were raised within the international community, with some speculating that the damage was not the result of sabotage. Due to the rapid growth in data volumes, subsea connections are becoming increasingly more important. Therefore, it can be expected that these critical connections will become targets of hostile acts as geopolitical conflicts intensify.^{9 10}

Additionally, international bodies such as the EU and NATO make a careful distinction between hazards and accidents that occur in the region. There are around 200 accidental subsea cable faults every year. The majority of the faults stem from human activities, such as fishing. In **Figure 2** below, you can observe the source of these damages, according to the International Cable Protection Committee (ICPC). “Third Party” and “Unknown” labels include possible intentional sabotage.

⁷ Himka, S. (2025, July 9). Baltic Sea undersea cable security. Henry M. Jackson School of International Studies, University of Washington. <https://jsis.washington.edu/news/baltic-sea-undersea-cable-security/>

⁸ Bidlingmaier, T. G. (1958, September). The strategic importance of the Baltic Sea. Proceedings, 84(9). <https://www.usni.org/magazines/proceedings/1958/september/strategic-importance-baltic-sea>

⁹ Muuga, Emilia & Loik, Ramon & Kaup, Georg-Henri & Savimaa, Raul & Koort, Erkki. (2025). Security Threats to the Undersea Connections Related Critical Infrastructure of the Baltic States: The Baltic Sea in the Focus of Hybrid Warfare. 10.15158/nv7t-kg46.

¹⁰ Henry M. Jackson School of International Studies. (2025). Baltic Sea undersea cable security. University of Washington. <https://jsis.washington.edu/news/baltic-sea-undersea-cable-security/>

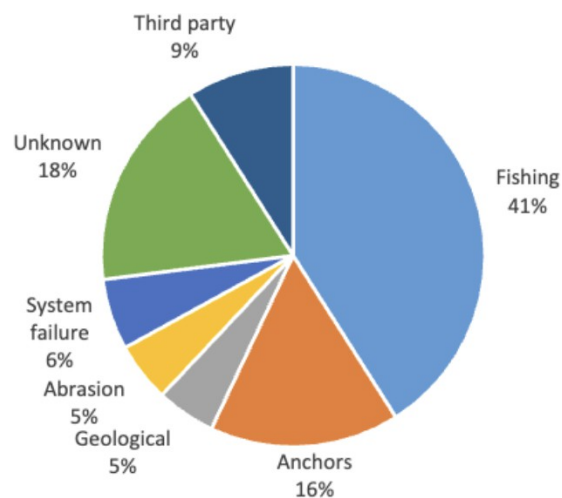


Figure 2 - Distribution of causes for subsea cable damage (1959 - 2021)¹¹ Last year, in March of 2025, the China Ship Scientific Research Center (CSSRC) and its affiliated State Key Laboratory of Deep-sea Manned Vehicles developed a ship able to cut cable lines at depths of up to 4,000 meters (13,123 feet). While China argues that the development of this equipment is purely for marine resource development, it still has caused further concern in the international community.^{12 13}

ICPC has issued recommendations for accident prevention, including implementing monitoring systems and patrols. NATO has actually implemented flotilla patrols in the Baltic Sea.¹³

Geography and natural resources¹⁴

The geographical aspect of the tension is crucial. The Baltic Sea is shallow and enclosed, accessible through three straits: the Great Belt, the Little Belt, and Øresund.

Electricity: the Baltic Sea region hosts numerous critical cross-border power cables connecting the Baltic states, Nordic countries, Poland, and Germany:

- The NordBalt cable between Lithuania and Sweden,

¹¹ Pohoryles, D. A., Risks and protection of subsea cable networks, Publications Office of the European Union, 2025, p. 6, <https://data.europa.eu/doi/10.2760/0196933>

¹² ibid

¹³ ibid

¹⁴ Murphy, E. L., & Pearl, M., 2025, April, China's underwater power play: The PRC's new subsea cable-cutting ship spooks international security experts. Center for Strategic and International Studies. <https://www.csis.org/analysis/chinas-underwater-power-play-prcs-new-subsea-cable-cutting-ship-spooks-international>

- The Estlink 1 and Estlink 2 high-voltage direct current (HVDC) interconnectors between Finland and Estonia
- The SwePol cable between Sweden and Poland
- The Baltic Cable between Sweden and Germany
- Planned: Estlink 3 and Harmony Link interconnectors

Gas: the basin carries the Balticconnector pipeline between Finland and Estonia, and the Baltic Pipe from Norway through Denmark to Poland. The North Sea–Baltic data backbone runs through the C-Lion1 cable between Finland and Germany and the BCS East-West cable between Lithuania and Sweden.¹⁵

Vulnerability and danger

The vulnerable nature of the cables, comprising extensive length and poor accessibility, makes them, unfortunately, easy and attractive targets for hybrid warfare. In late 2023, the Baltic Sea became a central theater of Russia's undeclared hybrid war against NATO and its allies. It was the frequency, location, and methods of cable severance that pointed to a possible hybrid campaign, with Russia as the prime suspect.¹⁶

¹⁵ Nordic Energy Research. (2026). Nordic energy security in two regional contexts: The Baltic and the Arctic. <https://pub.norden.org/nordicenergyresearch2026-02/section-4-nordic-energy-security-in-two-regional-contexts-the-baltic-and-the-arctic.html>

¹⁶ International Centre for Defence and Security. (2025). The Baltic Sea in peace and war. <https://icds.ee/en/the-baltic-sea-in-peace-and-war/>

05

Past Actions and Current Situation

The Baltic Sea is now the most closely watched stretch of water in the NATO area. With Finland and Sweden's accession, nine of the eleven coastal states are Alliance members, leading many observers to call it a "NATO lake".¹⁷ However, that near encirclement has not made the sea safer.

Beneath it run more than thirty cross-border cables and pipelines. Since 2022 about ten of them have been cut or damaged, with seven of those cuts concentrated in the three months between November 2024 and January 2025.¹⁸ The basin has become, in the framing of one recent analysis, "ground zero for the targeting of critical undersea infrastructure".¹⁹

The pattern began with Nord Stream. In September 2022 the two pipelines were ruptured by explosions in the Swedish and Danish economic zones.²⁰ Although Sweden recovered

¹⁷ Braw, E. (2025). How the Baltic Sea nations have tackled suspicious cable cuts. Atlantic Council. <https://www.atlanticcouncil.org/in-depth-research-reports/issue-brief/how-the-baltic-sea-nations-have-tackled-suspicious-cable-cuts/>

¹⁸ Buchholz, K. (2025). 11 Baltic cables damaged in 15 months, pushing NATO to boost security. DGfGnsG KGws. <https://www.defensenews.com/global/europe/2025/01/28/11-baltic-cables-damaged-in-15-months-pushing-nato-to-boost-security/>;

¹⁹ Jackson School of International Studies. (2025). Baltic Sea undersea cable security. University of Washington. <https://jsis.washington.edu/news/baltic-sea-undersea-cable-security/>

²⁰ Security Council Report. (2025, August). The Nord Stream incident: Open briefing. <https://www.securitycouncilreport.org/whatsinblue/2025/08/the-nord-stream-incident-open-briefing-2.php>

traces of explosives confirming deliberate sabotage, Sweden and Denmark closed their investigations in 2024 without naming a state.²¹

A year later, the method changed. In October 2023, the Balticconnector gas pipeline between Finland and Estonia was damaged when the Hong Kong-flagged, Chinese-owned container ship Newnew Polar Bear dragged its anchor along the seabed, striking the pipeline and nearby data cables.²² The most consequential case came weeks later, when the shadow fleet tanker Eagle S damaged the cables connecting Estonia and Finland on 25 December 2024, cutting the Estlink 2 power link, and Finland responded by seizing the vessel and bringing charges against its crew.²³

The incidents did not stop in 2025.

- **January:** A Latvia to Sweden cable near Gotland was damaged
- **February:** The C-Lion1 line was hit a third time.
- **May:** The Estonian Navy intercepted the suspected Russian-affiliated tanker *Jaguar*, operating under a Gabon flag, but could not forcibly board it given its limited naval capacity and the presence of a Russian fighter jet escorting the ship.
- **December:** A fiber-optic line connecting Helsinki and Tallinn was disrupted, triggering a full national response from Finnish authorities.

NATO's response: Baltic Sentry

NATO's institutional response has taken shape quickly. At a Summit of Baltic Sea Allies in Helsinki on January 14, 2025, Secretary General Mark Rutte announced the launch of Baltic Sentry to enhance NATO's military presence in the Baltic Sea and improve Allies' ability to respond to destabilizing acts.²⁴

This initiative involves:

-
- ²¹ Sweden ends Nord Stream sabotage probe, hands evidence to Germany. (2024, February 7). RGuTGrS. [https://www.reuters.com/world/europe/sweden-ends-investigation-into-nord-stream-pipe line-blasts-2024-02-07/](https://www.reuters.com/world/europe/sweden-ends-investigation-into-nord-stream-pipe-line-blasts-2024-02-07/)
 - ²² Beyond the Eagle S: How Yi Peng 3 and Newnew Polar Bear wreaked havoc in Baltic Sea. <https://www.cbsnews.com/news/eagle-s-how-yi-peng-3-and-newnew-polar-bear-wreaked-havoc-in-baltic-sea-60-minutes/>
 - ²³ Finland boards oil tanker suspected of causing internet, power cable damage in Baltic. (2024, December 26). RGuTGrS. <https://www.reuters.com/world/europe/finland-police-investigate-role-foreign-ship-after-power-cable-outage-2024-12-26/>
 - ²⁴ NATO launches "Baltic Sentry" to increase critical infrastructure security. (2025, January 14). North Atlantic Treaty Organization. <https://www.nato.int/en/news-and-events/articles/news/2025/01/14/nato-launches-baltic-sentry-to-increase-critical-infrastructure-security>

- Frigates and maritime patrol aircraft
- A small fleet of naval drones
- Integration of national surveillance systems
- A new NATO Maritime Centre for the Security of Critical Undersea Infrastructure
- A Critical Undersea Infrastructure Network that brings industry into the response

In parallel, the United Kingdom launched a Joint Expeditionary Force operation, Nordic Warden, which uses artificial intelligence to register shadow fleet vessels and signal allies when a risk is detected.²⁵ The system monitors 22 areas of interest, including parts of the English Channel, the North Sea, Kattegat, and Baltic Sea, from the operational headquarters in Northwood, London.²⁶ Rutte was explicit that enforcement would be firm, citing Finland's seizures as the benchmark and warning that ship captains face possible boarding, impounding, and arrest.²⁷

Legal challenges

The harder problem, and the one this committee must sit with, is that these acts are engineered to fall below the line at which NATO can clearly act:

- **Freedom of navigation:** vessels in international waters enjoy freedom of navigation under UNCLOS
- **Port-state limitations:** port states can deny entry or inspect, but shadow fleet vessels typically avoid NATO ports,
- **Sanctions:** sanctions target ownership and insurance rather than the vessels themselves.
- **Weak treaty provisions:** UNCLOS Article 113 only obliges states to criminalise damage to a submarine cable and grants no authority to enforce against foreign ships.

²⁵ British-led force to use AI in tracking Russia's shadow fleet. (2025, January 7). DGfGnsG KGws. <https://www.defensenews.com/global/europe/2025/01/07/british-led-force-to-use-ai-in-tracking-russias-shadow-fleet/>

²⁶ UK-led JEF activates Nordic Warden. (2025, January 6). Joint Forces News. <https://www.joint-forces.com/world-news/defence-news/78866-uk-led-jef-activates-nordic-warden>

²⁷ NATO launches "Baltic Sentry," 2025; Nato flotilla assembles off Estonia to protect undersea cables in Baltic Sea. (2025, January 19). ThG Guardian. <https://www.theguardian.com/world/2025/jan/19/nato-flotilla-assembles-off-estonia-protect-undersea-cables-baltic-sea>

- **Attribution:** an anchor cut is as plausibly an accident as sabotage, and that ambiguity is the point.

NATO's 2022 Strategic Concept acknowledges that hybrid operations could reach the level of an armed attack and trigger collective defence.²⁸ Yet no precedent exists for infrastructure sabotage crossing that threshold, and the only Article 5 invocation in NATO's history followed the September 11, 2001 attacks.²⁹

The stakes are concrete rather than theoretical:

- More than 95 percent of internet traffic is carried by undersea cables
- Roughly 1.3 million kilometres of cabling underpins an estimated 10 trillion dollars of financial transactions every day
- A coordinated strike on the Estlink interconnectors or the regional data backbone is a direct hit to the energy and communications security of frontline member states.
- Each unanswered incident also lowers the cost of the next

The question in front of this committee is therefore not whether the threat is real, but how an alliance built to defend territory responds to a sustained campaign aimed at the seabed beneath it, using tools that international law was never written to provide.

²⁸ North Atlantic Treaty Organization. (2022). NATO 2022 Strategic Concept. <https://www.nato.int/content/dam/nato/webready/documents/publications-and-reports/strategic-concepts/2022/290622-strategic-concept.pdf>

²⁹ NATO Cooperative Cyber Defence Centre of Excellence. (n.d.). Cyber attacks and Article 5 – a note on a blurry but consistent position of NATO. <https://ccdcoe.org/incyber-articles/cyber-attacks-and-article-5-a-note-on-a-blurry-but-consistent-position-of-nato/>

06

Bloc Positions and Key Stakeholders

It would be a mistake to treat NATO as a single voice on this issue. The Alliance agrees that the cuts are a threat, but it splits along a predictable line: the states most exposed to the cables want rapid, forceful response, while those with larger merchant fleets and more distant coastlines weigh the precedent any forceful action would set.

Complicating this further, NATO itself is not legally the first responder. As officers inside the Alliance's own Baltic task force have stressed, the response to a suspected attack rests with the affected coastal state and its legal system. Cable owners hold primary responsibility for their security, with NATO there to assist rather than to provide blanket protection.

Baltic States

The frontline Baltic states, Estonia, Latvia, and Lithuania, are the most hawkish bloc. They are small, almost entirely dependent on a handful of cables for power and data, and they read every incident through the lens of Russian hybrid pressure on NATO's eastern flank. All three remain firmly committed to NATO and active in the Baltic Sentry.³⁰

After the Estlink 2 cut, Estonia's foreign minister framed the damage as an attack on vital infrastructure rather than an accident.³¹ Their problem is capability, not will. These states

³⁰ Jackson School of International Studies. (2025). Baltic Sea undersea cable security. University of Washington

³¹ Finland boards oil tanker suspected of causing internet, power cable damage in Baltic. (2024, December 26). RGuTGrS.

historically built land forces and left the sea to others, and their navies are limited, a gap exposed in May 2025 when the Estonian Navy approached the sanctioned tanker Jaguar, whose Gabon registration had just been revoked, but found how little margin a small navy has when a vessel refuses to comply and a Russian jet shadows the operation.³²

Lithuania, which lost roughly a fifth of its internet capacity in the November 2024 cuts, has leaned on public-private cooperation, signing an agreement between its armed forces and the grid operator Litgrid to protect critical subsea links.³³

Finland and Sweden

Finland and Sweden, the newest members, sit slightly apart as the enforcement test cases. Finland set the benchmark the rest of the Alliance now cites, escorting the Eagle S into its territorial waters, boarding it, and detaining ship and cargo, with President Stubb arguing that three cable incidents in a single year could not be coincidence.³⁴

Yet both countries also illustrate the limits of going hard. Sweden seized the Vezhen after the Gotland cable damage but released it once prosecutors concluded the anchor had likely dropped accidentally in high winds.³⁵ A Finnish court later dismissed the case against the Eagle S crew, ruling that prosecutors had not proven intent and that any negligence had to be pursued by the flag state or the crew's home countries. The lesson for delegates is that even the toughest responders keep running into the same evidentiary wall.³⁶

Larger Western Members

The larger Western members carry the operational weight but move more cautiously.

³² Estonia says Russia sent jet after attempt to stop sanction-breaking tanker. (2025, May 15). RGuGrS

³³ Lithuanian army, power grid operator to boost security of subsea infrastructure. (2025). BBC KGws

³⁴ Finland seizes Russian oil tanker after suspected undersea fiber-optic cable sabotage. (2024, December 27). USKI KGws. <https://news.usni.org/2024/12/27/finland-seizes-russian-oil-tanker-after-suspected-under-sea-fiber-optic-cable-sabotage>

³⁵ Sweden says ship broke Baltic Sea cable by accident. (2025, February 3). RGuGrS. <https://www.reuters.com/world/europe/sweden-rules-out-sabotage-baltic-sea-cable-dam-age-case-2025-02-03/>

³⁶ Finland's Eagle S decision: How the deep sea goes dark when international law fails to protect states from underwater sabotage. (2025, December). Washington IntGrnational Law Journal. <https://wilj.org/2025/12/04/finlands-eagle-s-decisionwhen-the-deep-sea-goes-dark-when-international-law-fails-to-protect-states-from-underwater-sabotage/>

- Germany has become the regional coordinator, running Commander Task Force Baltic out of Rostock on behalf of NATO's Maritime Command, with Defence Minister Pistorius among the most willing to name Russia openly.³⁷
- The United Kingdom leads the parallel Joint Expeditionary Force track, activating the AI-driven Nordic Warden system, shadowing Russian vessels such as the spy ship Yantar, and sanctioning more than a hundred shadow fleet ships in May 2025.³⁸
- The United States engaged early through Nordic-Baltic cyber and infrastructure coordination, though the depth of sustained American commitment is an open question delegates should probe.³⁹
- Denmark, holding the straits that are the only exits from the sea, is a natural gatekeeper but also belongs to the bloc of major maritime trading nations wary that aggressive interdiction in the Baltic could be turned against their own vessels elsewhere.⁴⁰

Russia

Russia is the actor every position paper must address, and its stance is flat denial. The Kremlin has dismissed seizures as a matter of little concern and rejects responsibility for the incidents.⁴¹

Behind the denial sits the shadow fleet, the instrument that makes the strategy work. Since 2022 Russia has assembled more than 400 ageing tankers used to export oil and, allegedly, to sabotage undersea cables.⁴² More than 60% of Russian seaborne crude passes through the Baltic. These vessels change flags often and carry no Western insurance, giving Moscow plausible deniability. Russia has also begun escorting these vessels and signalling a readiness to intervene militarily on their behalf, a dangerous step in an already securitised sea.⁴³

³⁷ Braw, E. (2025). How the Baltic Sea nations have tackled suspicious cable cuts. Atlantic Council.

³⁸ British-led force to use AI in tracking Russia's shadow fleet. (2025, January 7). DGfiGnsG KGws

³⁹ Jackson School of International Studies. (2025). Baltic Sea undersea cable security. University of Washington

⁴⁰ Braw, E. (2025). The shadow fleet is undermining the maritime order more brazenly than ever. Atlantic Council.

⁴¹ Finland says vessel suspected of cutting cable may be part of Russia's shadow fleet. (2024, December 26). ThG KGw York TimGs. <https://www.nytimes.com/2024/12/26/world/europe/finland-estonia-cables-russia.html>

⁴² Russia's shadow fleet: A masterclass in sanctions evasion. (2024). GGopolitical Monitor. <https://www.geopoliticalmonitor.com/russias-shadow-fleet-a-masterclass-in-sanctions-ev asion/>

⁴³ Estonia says Russia sent jet after attempt to stop sanction-breaking tanker. (2025, May 15). RGutGrs

China

China is the quieter but unavoidable stakeholder, present through the vessels themselves. Its pattern has been to deny, delay, then concede minimally: Beijing first denied the Newnew Polar Bear's involvement and only later admitted the ship caused the damage, attributing it to bad weather and an accident.⁴⁴ Over the Yi Peng 3, China permitted a limited joint inspection after a month-long standoff while refusing to let the ship enter Swedish jurisdiction.⁴⁵

European concern about Chinese leverage over critical infrastructure runs wider than these incidents, with the European Parliament flagging the risks of Chinese firms acquiring European internet companies and of suppliers such as HMN Technologies.⁴⁶

Non-state actors and private operators

The non-state layer is central rather than peripheral. The cables and pipelines are largely privately owned, by operators such as Cinia, Arelion, Litgrid, and Elisa, which means commercial firms sit on the front line of a security problem and bear first responsibility for repair and resilience.⁴⁷

The shadow fleet's enablers, the flag-of-convenience registries, opaque shell owners like the United Arab Emirates company behind the Eagle S, and the insurers and tracking systems these vessels exploit, are exactly where enforcement pressure is now aimed.⁴⁸

The European Union has stepped in as an institutional actor in its own right, publishing an Action Plan on Cable Security in February 2025 and committing close to a billion euros to surveillance and a fleet of emergency repair vessels.⁴⁹ For delegates, the practical question is how a NATO committee divides labour with the EU, with private operators, and with the flag states whose cooperation any lasting solution requires.

⁴⁴ Beijing's Baltic confession exposes undersea vulnerability. (2024). ThG IntGrprGtGr, Lowy Institute. <https://www.lowyinstitute.org/the-interpreter/beijing-s-baltic-confession-exposes-undersea-vulnerability>

⁴⁵ China lets Sweden, Finland, Germany and Denmark board ship in cable probe. (2024, December 19). RGuTGrS

⁴⁶ A Chinese-flagged ship cut Baltic Sea internet cables. This time, Europe was watching. (2024, December). Carnegie Endowment for International Peace. <https://carnegieendowment.org/emissary/2024/12/baltic-sea-internet-cable-cut-europe-nato-security>

⁴⁷ Braw, E. (2025). How the Baltic Sea nations have tackled suspicious cable cuts. Atlantic Council

⁴⁸ Russia-linked cable-cutting tanker seized by Finland "was loaded with spying equipment." (2025). Lloyd's List. <https://www.lloydslist.com/LL1151955/Russia-linked-cable-cutting-tanker-seized-by-Finland-was-loaded-with-spying-equipment>

⁴⁹ European Commission & High Representative. (2025, February 21). EU Action Plan on Cable Security (JOIN/2025/9). <https://eur-lex.europa.eu/legal-content/EN/TXT/?uri=celex:52025JC0009>

07

QARMAs

- 1 What rules of engagement should apply when suspected vessels refuse to comply with boarding requests in international waters, given that vessels enjoy freedom of navigation under UNCLOS?
- 2 How should NATO deal with the evidentiary challenges of proving intent, given that anchor-dragging incidents are designed to appear as plausible accidents rather than sabotage, as demonstrated by the dismissal of the Eagle S crew case in Finland?
- 3 How should NATO enhance its military surveillance and patrol presence in the Baltic Sea beyond the current Baltic Sentry operation, and what additional assets (frigates, drones, maritime patrol aircraft) should be deployed?
- 4 How can the Alliance address the capability gap of frontline Baltic states (Estonia, Latvia, Lithuania), which are the most exposed but have historically prioritized land forces over naval capacity?
- 5 What role should AI-driven surveillance systems, such as the UK's Nordic Warden system, play in tracking and flagging shadow fleet vessels across the region?
- 6 What role should public-private cooperation play, following models like Lithuania's agreement between its armed forces and grid operator Litgrid?

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